A MILITARY SUPERPOWER

TO BECOME A MILITARY GIANT, INDIA MUST INVEST MORE IN DEVELOPING THE LATEST TECHNOLOGIES, BE ABLE TO PROJECT POWER IN THE INDIAN OCEAN AND FORGE STRATEGIC ALLIANCES

By **Pradip R. Sagar**

Given the comprehensive nature of its defence assets, which span land, sea and air, India seems well positioned to meet the security challenges in a fast-changing world. What helps is that it possesses a nuclear arsenal and has developed a credible nuclear triad, allowing it to deliver nuclear weapons from land, air and sea. This strength in fundamentals also bolsters its influence in geopolitics. India's ranking as the fourth most powerful military in the world according to the 2024 Global Firepower Index reflects its significant role in regional security. But in order to emerge as a major global power in defence, it needs to do plenty more.

For, though India is undoubtedly a regional military power, it is not classified as a 'military superpower' like the US, Russia and China. Experts believe that India's aspiration to become one calls for a multifaceted approach. It involves modernising its armed forces, forging strong international alliances, enhancing training, investing in research and development, boosting cyber warfare and space capabilities, strengthening maritime power, securing economic and industrial support, sharpening intelligence and surveillance, integrating Artificial Intelligence and quantum computing, maintaining nuclear deterrence, even leveraging soft power and diplomacy.

UPSURGE IN SPENDING

Rising regional tensions, particularly with China and Pakistan, amid global security challenges have driven a continuous uptick in India's military spending. While India's defence outlay is just below 2 per cent of the country's GDP (as per this year's budget), we still rank as the world's fourth-largest military spender—behind only the US, China and Russia. The defence budget for FY25 stood at Rs 6.21 lakh crore, marking a 4.72 per cent increase from the previous year, with a substantial focus on capital expenditure to modernise defence capabilities and big-ticket acquisitions. Almost a third of the budget—Rs 1.72 lakh crore—is the capital outlay for modernisation. Estimates suggest that the Indian armed forces will spend $130 billion (Rs 10.89 lakh crore) on capital procurement over the next five-six years.

Along with modernisation, investing in R&D through institutions like the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO)—in collaboration with the private sector wherever feasible—is critical for accelerated development of cutting-edge solutions. While the DRDO gets an outlay of Rs 23,855 crore, another Rs 13,208 crore is earmarked for fundamental research and developing new technology.

STRENGTH OF OUR FORCES

On the face of it, the Indian military's inventory is impressive. The 1.4 million-strong Indian Army has 4,750 tanks, more than 10,000 armoured vehicles and over 4,000 modern artillery pieces. In addition, there are rocket launchers, nuclear missiles, intercontinental ballistic missiles (ICBMs), tactical ballistic missiles and additional platforms in other branches. The Indian Air Force (IAF) has 170,576 active personnel and over 1,926 aircraft, making it the fourth largest air force in the world. The Indian Navy operates a variety of warships, including two aircraft carriers, 12 destroyers, 12 frigates, 18 corvettes and 16 submarines. The naval force also aspires to having a 175-ship fleet in the next 10 years.

However, there is no room for complacency. Former army chief Gen. Manoj Pande had once said that "we cannot fight

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